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SILENCING THE DOCTRINE OF DISCOVERY - THE BRAZILIAN PROCESS ACCIDENTAL DISCOVERIES, SECRET MANUSCRIPTS, IMAGINARY LINES AND MYTHS

Abstract

This article examines the historical silence surrounding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery and its impact on Brazilian society. It explores how papal bulls, known as the Doctrine of Discovery, have shaped power dynamics, enabling certain narratives while silencing others. Drawing on Michel-Rolph Trouillot and Franz Fanon, the study analyzes the construction of historical silence and its connection to violence against Indigenous peoples. It argues that the Church's role in upholding elite dominance has contributed to the narrative of the Doctrine's irrelevance, paralleling the myth of racial democracy in Brazil. The silence surrounding the Doctrine is linked to systemic racism, with Indigenous peoples experiencing unthinkable violence during colonization. The article contends that addressing this colonial past, especially its ties to the Church, is essential for disrupting neocolonial practices and Eurocentric narratives. It calls for the Church to take active steps in dismantling the Doctrine, fulfilling commitments to Indigenous rights, and contributing to global decolonization efforts.

Keywords: *Doctrine of Discovery, Indigenous Peoples, Amazon Forest, Environment, Colonialism, Imperialism, Tordesillas Treaty, USAID, MEC, Manifest Destiny, Christianity, Brazil, Terra Nullius, Inter Caetera, Eurocentrism, colonialism, historicity, History*

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History is the fruit of power, but power itself is never so transparent that its analysis becomes superfluous. The ultimate mark of power may be its invisibility; the ultimate challenge, the exposition of its roots.[2]

- Michel-Rolph Trouillot, Silencing the Past, 1995

Introduction

In 1095, Pope Urban II issued *Terra Nullius* ("empty land"), a papal bull that decreed all land controlled by Christian empires was legitimately owned by them. This event set the stage for establishing the legal basis of land ownership during the Colonial Era, shaping land ownership rights in many parts of the world today.

Terra Nullius was followed by a series of papal pronouncements (papal bulls) that collectively formed what became known as the Doctrine of Discovery. The far-reaching scope of the Doctrine's principles provides a powerful explanation for the oppression and violence faced by vulnerable groups, particularly Indigenous peoples, since the Colonial Era. Throughout history, Christianity has been used to justify the power of ruling elites.[3] Acknowledging the full implications of the Doctrine of Discovery exposes the moral and ethical contradictions inherent in Christianity, the Catholic Church, and the actions of settlers and colonizers.

The silence surrounding the Doctrine of Discovery has been maintained since the Colonial Era, as powerful elites continued to control knowledge production in many former colonies, including Brazil. Absent from mainstream Brazilian history books, the Doctrine of Discovery is deemed irrelevant in most Brazilian academic settings. In a country with the largest Catholic population in the world, the Doctrine and its ramifications are neither seriously questioned nor critically examined within their historical context. However, the continuous historical violence against Indigenous people, which began when Portuguese colonizers arrived in Brazil in 1500, cannot be fully confronted without understanding the Catholic Church's role in supporting the conquerors and colonizers. Dismantling the structures of knowledge production that exclude Indigenous voices while preserving hegemonic power structures requires a critical analysis of Brazilian history produced in ways that reflect and sustain the colonizer's narrative.

Decolonizing an educational system long affected by foreign interests demands recognizing the retrospective significance of the Doctrine of Discovery, which was used to justify the enslavement and dispossession of Indigenous peoples and the destruction of the environment.

Recently, Western countries have attempted to impose environmental regulations on Amazonian countries that echo the Doctrine's principles of domination from the era of discovery. At the 2023 Amazon Cooperation Treaty Organization climate summit between

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[2] Michel-Rolph Trouillot, *Silencing The Past: Power And The Production Of History* (Beacon Press, 1995), http://archive.org/details/michel-rolph-trouillot-silencing-the-past-power-and-the-production-of-history-beacon-press-1995.

[3] Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, with University of California Libraries (Routledge, 2002), http://archive.org/details/protestantethics00webe.

Brazil, Bolivia, Colombia, Ecuador, Guyana, Peru, Suriname, and Venezuela, Brazilian leadership pointed out that such rules amount to what has been called "green neocolonialism."[4] While threatening to impose commercial barriers on products from these countries if their regulations are not followed, summit participants emphasized the need to address the historical responsibilities of Western nations. Over the centuries, these nations have exploited natural resources and polluted the planet, perpetuating patterns of domination reminiscent of historical moments when papal bulls were used to serve the interests of those in power. Today, multinational corporations continue this legacy, engaging in environmental destruction while presenting themselves as protectors of the environment.

When carbon becomes subject to the dynamics of commodity fetishism, besides being a contemporary manifestation of colonial logic,[5] the situation mirrors the phenomenon Debord critiques in *The Society of the Spectacle*, where real environmental crises are obscuredby the fetishization of carbon credits and offset programs. These are presented as solutions but, in reality, serve to maintain the status quo. The spectacle transforms carbon into a mere image, disconnected from actual environmental damage, trapping societies within a system where representations replace material realities.[6] This process reflects what Debord refers to as the "autocratic reign of the market economy," where the fetishization of commodities, including carbon, distracts from the underlying social and ecological issues.[7] This dynamic enables continued environmental harm while sidelining meaningful change and reinforcing the status quo, echoing the exploitation and subjugation practices that originated with the Doctrine of Discovery.

Colonialism is not satisfied merely with holding a people in its grip and emptying the native's brain of all form and content. By a kind of perverted logic, it turns to the past of the oppressed people and distorts, disfigures, and destroys it.[8]

- Frantz Fanon, The Wretched of the Earth, 2022

Breaking the Silence

Terra Nullius - the Myth of Empty Land

Before European contact, the Americas were home to diverse Indigenous cultures and societies, making the concept of discovery both a legal and moral fallacy. Historian Jan De Vries estimates that in the 1500s, Europe had a population of 60 to 70 million people, while the Americas were inhabited by 50 to 100 million.[9] When Portuguese colonizers arrived in

[4] N G Gortázar, "Lula Accuses the E.U. of Disguising Protectionist Measures as Environmental Concerns," El País, 2023, https://english.elpais.com/international/2023-08-10/lula-accuses-the-eu-of-%20disguising-protectionist-measures-as-environmental-concern.html.

[5] Larry Lohmann, "Carbon Trading: A Critical Conversation on Climate Change, Privatisation and Power," *Development in Practice* 18, no. 3 (2008): 460–62, https://doi.org/10.1080/09614520802031241.

[6] Guy Debord, *Society of the Spectacle*, with Internet Archive (Black & Red, 1967), http://archive.org/details/societyofspectac0000unse.

[7] Guy Debord, *Comments on the Society of the Spectacle: Part II*, with Internet Archive (Verso, 1988), http://archive.org/details/commentsonsociet0000debo.

[8] Frantz Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth* (Grove Press, 2022).

[9] Charles C. Mann, *1491: New Revelations of the Americas Before Columbus*, with Internet Archive (Alfred A. Knopf, 2020), http://archive.org/details/149100char.

Brazil in 1500, at least seven million Indigenous people already lived there,[10] effectively dispelling the notion of *Terra Nullius* or "empty land."

The Myth of Accidental Discovery

For centuries, Brazilian history textbooks propagated the myth that Portuguese explorer Pedro Álvares Cabral accidentally discovered Brazil in 1500. This narrative suggests Cabral stumbled upon Brazil by chance, thereby downplaying the violent and intentional nature of Portuguese colonization.

In the 1980s, several documents contesting this notion emerged in Portugal,[11] calling into question the narrative of accidental discovery. However, the myth still prevails in the educational system, and the violent and exploitative nature of the colonization process continues to be downplayed. By framing Brazil's colonization as accidental, the Portuguese attempted to bypass the ethical and moral questions surrounding the domination and invasion of lands and peoples. If Brazil was discovered by accident, the Portuguese could argue they had stumbled upon the land without prior knowledge of its existence or the large Indigenous population inhabiting it.[12]

This myth allowed the Portuguese and later European colonizers to justify their violent actions, including the expulsion of Indigenous peoples from their lands, the imposition of colonial rule, the exploitation of natural resources, and the denial of Indigenous rights and sovereignty. Today, discussions of colonialism, Indigenous rights, and decolonization must evaluate the connections between the Doctrine of Discovery, the myth of accidental discovery, and the imbalance of power that has shaped dominant historical narratives.

Treaty of Tordesillas and the Secret Manuscripts "Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis"

From the earliest days of Portuguese arrival in Brazil, the silence surrounding the Doctrine of Discovery had already been consolidated. Recently revealed documents written by Portuguese sea captain, explorer, and cartographer Duarte Pacheco Pereira in 1498[13] provide evidence that Cabral's arrival in Brazil in 1500 was likely a planned event.

Upon Duarte's return from transoceanic voyages planned by King Manuel I of Portugal to expand the Portuguese Empire, he reported the existence of a large mainland east of the Tordesillas line, with many large islands adjacent to it. These findings were documented in the *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis* and other manuscripts written between 1505 and 1508.

The content of these documents was kept from public view for nearly four centuries by order of King Manuel I.[14] They contain nautical, geographical, and economic information gathered during Duarte Pereira's 1498 voyage to Brazil and the East Coast of Africa. *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis* was the first Portuguese manuscript to mention Brazil's coastline, the abundance of brazilwood (*Caesalpinia echinata*), and the possible extent of the land.

King Manuel I of Portugal ordered all information from Pereira's journeys to be withheld, considering it overly sensitive and wanting to avoid drawing attention from other

[10] Mann, *1491*.

[11] Frei Vincente do Salvador, *The History of Brazil, 1500–1627*, trans. Timothy Coates (Tagus Press, 2022), https://www.umasspress.com/9781951470173/the-history-of-brazil-15001627/.

[12] Mann, *1491*.

[13] do Salvador, *The History of Brazil, 1500–1627*.

[14] J.D. Fage, "A Commentary on Duarte Pacheco Pereira's Account of the Lower Guinea Coastlands in His Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis and Other Early Accounts," *History in Africa* 7 (1980): 47–80, https://doi.org/10.2307/3171656.

explorers. The Portuguese Crown never allowed public access to these records.[15] In 1493, the papal bull ***Inter caetera*** was issued by Pope Alexander VI, granting King Ferdinand II of Aragon and Queen Isabella I of Castile ownership of all lands west and south of a pole-to-pole line 100 leagues west and south of any of the Azores or Cabo Verde Islands. The original papal bull was officially altered in 1494 with the signing of the Treaty of Tordesillas, establishing that any newly discovered lands outside Europe along a meridian 370 leagues west of the Cape Verde islands, off the West African coast, would belong to Portugal. This new boundary allowed Portugal to claim Brazil's coastline following its supposed accidental discovery by Pedro Álvares Cabral in 1500.

Contemporary historians view the descriptions in *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis* and other manuscripts as evidence that Brazil was known to the Portuguese before 1500.[16] The original manuscript was lost, but two copies were found: one in the public library of Évora and the other in the National Library of Lisbon.

The first edition of Duarte Pacheco's work was published in 1892 during the celebration of the fourth centenary of the discovery of America by Portuguese paleographer Rafael Eduardo de Azevedo Bast. The second edition was not published until 1905.[17]

As a navigational and geographical treatise, ***Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis*** provides insights into Portuguese exploration during the Age of Discovery. A map created in 1502, the Cantino Planisphere, offers a detailed reconnaissance of Brazil's 7,491kilometer-long coastline, the 16th longest in the world, even before its so-called "accidental discovery" in 1500.

For the Portuguese, the narrative of accidental discovery removes the possibility of imagining aggressive invasion against the original inhabitants, facilitating the construction of a narrative tied to Christian ideals of salvation and redemption rather than the violence embedded in the principles of the Doctrine of Discovery.

For a cultural invasion to succeed, it is essential that those invaded become convinced of their intrinsic inferiority.[18]

- Paulo Freire, Pedagogy of the Oppressed, 1972

The Historical Silencing of the Doctrine of Discovery: A Brazilian Perspective on American Cultural Invasion

By the late 19th century, when *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis* became widely known, the narrative of Brazil's accidental discovery had already been integrated into official historiography and educational curricula. This narrative persisted through the Brazilian imperial period and post-independence, promoting the idea that the Church and Portugal brought Christianity, salvation, and progress to Indigenous peoples.

The first historical account of Brazil, written in 1627 by Franciscan friar Vicente do Salvador, omits both the intentionality behind the Portuguese expedition and the Church's

[15] Jorge Couto, *Livro A Construção Do Brasil* (Forense Universitária, 2011), https://sesc.i10bibliotecas.com.br/livro/695223; Louis-André Vigneras, *The Discovery of South America and the Andalusian Voyages* (University of Chicago Press, 1976), 142, https://cir.nii.ac.jp/crid/1130282268729747712.

[16] John A. Crow, *The Epic of Latin America*, 4th ed. (University of California Press, 1992).

[17] T.O. Marcondes De Souza, "Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis," *Revista de História* 12, no. 26 (1956): 551–52, https://doi.org/10.11606/issn.2316-9141.v12i26p551-552.

[18] Paulo Freire, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, trans. Myra Bergman Ramos (Herder and Herder, 1972), https://www.penguin.co.uk/books/22583/pedagogy-of-the-oppressed-by-freire-paulo/9780241301111.

ties to the Crown. Over two centuries later, in 1861, Joaquim Manuel de Macedo's *Lições de História do Brasil* similarly avoided these issues, reinforcing a sanitized version of Brazil's colonial history.[19] Even today, the connections between the Doctrine of Discovery, Brazil's colonization, and centuries of violence against Indigenous peoples remain suppressed, obscuring the Doctrine's links to slavery, racism, and inequality. This silence perpetuates the narratives constructed by those who shaped historical archives, preserving Western dominance that began with Portugal, Spain, and the Church in the 15th century.[20] This continued omission in global and Brazilian historiography, reflected in textbooks across the Global South, prevents a critical understanding of colonialism's enduring impact. Addressing this silence is essential to deconstructing the roots of social inequality and racism in Brazil, where elite control over knowledge production still reflects Western superiority.

Imperialism and the Legacy of the Doctrine of Discovery

The Doctrine of Discovery has shaped not only the colonization of the Americas but also subsequent interventions by Western powers. In the early 20th century, U.S. imperialism in Latin America followed similar patterns of exploitation and domination, as exemplified by the Roosevelt- Rondon Scientific Expedition in 1914.

The expedition was described in detail in Roosevelt's book *Through the Brazilian Wilderness*.[21] It mentions encounters with isolated Indigenous peoples, incursions into virgin native lands in search of resources, and the hunting and capturing of animals. Roosevelt wrote "The country, when opened, will be a healthy abode for white settlers."[22]

Like Lewis and Clark in their 1804 expedition across North America, the Roosevelts and Candido Rondon were pioneers in the modern-day exploitation and expropriation of Indigenous Brazilian lands and resources.

The American Monroe Doctrine Reinterpreted: The 1928 Clark Memorandum The Exotic Good Neighbor[23]

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[19] Arlette Medeiros Gasparello, "Homens de Letras No Magistério: Joaquim Manuel de Macedo e a Construção de Uma História Escolar," *Revista de História* 0, no. 164 (2011): 463, https://doi.org/10.11606/issn.2316-9141.v0i164p463-485; Joaquim Manuel de Macedo, *Lições De Historia Do Brasil Para Uso Das Escolas De Instrucção Primaria*, with unknown library (Typ. Imparcial de J. M. N. Garcia, 1861), http://archive.org/details/liesdehistoriad00macegoog.

[20] Michel-Rolph Trouillot, *Silencing The Past: Power And The Production Of History* (Beacon Press, 2015), 99, http://archive.org/details/michel-rolph-trouillot-silencing-the-past-power-and-the-production-of-history-beacon-press-1995.

[21] Theodore Roosevelt, *Through the Brazilian Wilderness*, with Robarts - University of Toronto (Scribner, c1914), http://archive.org/details/throughbrazilian00roosuoft.

[22] Roosevelt, *Through the Brazilian Wilderness*, 320.

[23] The 1928 Clark Memorandum is an important document in U.S. foreign policy history, particularly regarding the Monroe Doctrine and its application to Latin America. Drafted by J. Reuben Clark, the U.S. Undersecretary of State under President Calvin Coolidge, the memorandum was intended to clarify and redefine the scope of the Monroe Doctrine of 1823. The Memorandum was not officially adopted as policy when it was written, but it influenced President Franklin D. Roosevelt's Good Neighbor Policy in the 1930s. Its key points were:
- It argued that the Monroe Doctrine was intended solely to prevent European intervention in the Western Hemisphere and was not meant to justify U.S. intervention in Latin America. It clarified that the Doctrine was a defense against European colonialism, not a tool for asserting U.S. control over Latin American countries. Peter H. Smith, *Talons of the Eagle : Dynamics of U.S.-Latin American Relations*, with Internet Archive (Oxford University Press, 1994), http://archive.org/details/talonsofeagledyn00smit.
- It rejected Roosevelt Corollary to the Monroe Doctrine (1904), which had expanded the original Doctrine to justify U.S. intervention in Latin American countries to stabilize the region and protect U.S. interests. Under the Roosevelt Corollary, the U.S. had intervened in the domestic affairs of several Latin American nations. Walter LaFeber, *The American Age: United States Foreign Policy at Home and Abroad Since 1750*, with Internet Archive (Norton, 1989), http://archive.org/details/americanageunite00lafe.

The United States, as the largest empire in history, has profoundly influenced contemporary societies through its strategies, media, and culture. The Clark Memorandum on the Monroe Doctrine, issued on December 17, 1928, authorized U.S. military intervention in Latin America, including Brazil.[24] This policy, rooted in the ideology of Manifest Destiny, which justified territorial expansion at the expense of Native Americans,[25] was followed by the Good Neighbor Policy in 1930, building on the Clark Memorandum.[26]

The Good Neighbor Policy reflected a sense of U.S. superiority, much like the earlier territorial claims made by Spain and Portugal under the 1494 Treaty of Tordesillas. In Latin America, this superiority was symbolized by figures like Carmen Miranda, the "Lady in the Tutti-Frutti Hat." Miranda, a Portuguese-born immigrant to Brazil, became the face of Latin American exoticism in U.S. popular culture. Her portrayal of the Baiana, based on the attire of impoverished Afro-Brazilian women from Bahia, reinforced stereotypes of Brazil and Latin America as the exotic "other." "To the Global South, the Good Neighbor's face became that of singer Carmen Miranda, named "The Lady in the Tutti-Frutti Hat"—a woman adorned with a large hat wrapped in fruit, singing and dancing the Brazilian samba."[27] This image, lacking authenticity or cultural significance, reflected American constructions of Latin identity rather than true Brazilian culture.

Continuing the Good Neighbor Policy, the U.S. launched the Alliance for Progress in 1961, ostensibly aimed at supporting the development of the "third world."[28] Shortly after, in 1964, a U.S.-backed military dictatorship took power in Brazil, a pattern mirrored throughout South America. By the late 1990s, it became clear that these interventions were part of Operation Condor, a CIA-supported campaign of political repression, coups, assassinations, and torture aimed at left-wing leaders in South America from 1968 to 1989.[29] This intervention permanently reshaped Brazil's political and educational systems.

The Dismantling of Brazil's Educational Legacy: From a French Socially-Oriented Educational Model to an American Market-Driven one

The Impact of the 1964 USAID/MEC Agreements on Brazil's Education System

- It emphasized the importance of respecting the sovereignty of Latin American countries and reducing U.S. military intervention in the region. Lester D. Langley, *The Banana Wars: United States Intervention in the Caribbean, 1898-1934*, with Internet Archive (SR Books, 2002), http://archive.org/details/bananawarsunited0000lang.
- The Good Neighbor Policy temporarily marked a shift away from U.S. military intervention and toward diplomacy and cooperation with Latin American countries. Hans J Schmidt, *The United States and Latin America: A History of American Diplomac,* (Wiley-Blackwell, 2000), https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203004531.

[24] Bruce W. Jentleson and Thomas G. Paterson, *Encyclopedia of U.S. Foreign Relations*, with Internet Archive (Oxford University Press, 1997), http://archive.org/details/encyclopediaofus01jent.

[25] Daniel Immerwahr, *How to Hide an Empire: A History of the Greater United States* (Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2019), https://www.amazon.com/How-Hide-Empire-History-Greater/dp/0374172145.

[26] Mark T Gilderhus, "The Monroe Doctrine: Meanings and Implications," *Presidential Studies Quarterly* 36, no. 1 (2006): 113, https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-5705.2006.00282.x.

[27] Krista A. Thompson, *An Eye for the Tropics: Tourism, Photography, and Framing the Caribbean Picturesque,* 2007, https://doi.org/10.1515/9780822388562; Mara Rúbia Sant'Anna and Káritha Bernardo Macedo, "Images of Latin America in the Body and Costumes of Carmen Miranda's Stylized 'Baiana': Social Memory and Identity," *Comunicação E Sociedade* 24 (December 30, 2013): 186–209, https://doi.org/10.17231/comsoc.24(2013).1783.

[28] Peter H. Smith, *Talons of the Eagle : Dynamics of U.S.-Latin American Relations*, with Internet Archive (Oxford University Press, 2000), http://archive.org/details/talonsofeagledyn00smit.

[29] A. J. Langguth, *Hidden Terrors: The Truth About U.S. Police Operations in Latin America* (Open Road Integrated Media, 2018), http://archive.org/details/hidden-terrors-the-truth-about.

On April 1, 1964, a U.S.- backed military coup ousted Brazil's democratically elected president, João Goulart, and installed a military regime that lasted 21 years.[30] The Catholic Church and Brazilian elites played a key role in legitimizing the interests of those who supported the coup.

During the regime, scholars and students were persecuted, with many disappearing or being tortured. Amidst this repression, the Brazilian Ministry of Education and Culture (MEC) and the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) signed an agreement.[31] The agreement involved a contract with the San Diego State College Foundation, which provided American experts to assist in reforming Brazil's educational system along North American lines. Many regime sympathizers were sent to the United States for training, with the objective of promoting ideologies aligned with U.S. interests.[32]

Freire, imprisoned for 70 days and later forced into exile, saw his publications and methods banned. His influential work, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1968), was not published in Brazil until 1974. Freire argued that this model of education served capitalist interests by molding individuals into a compliant labor force, and was not published in Brazil until 1974. Freire argued that this model of education served capitalist interests by molding individuals into a compliant labor force, reinforcing the relationship between colonizers and the colonized. He described this process as "cultural invasion, where invaders mold; those they invade are molded."[33]

Pedagogical training for the USAID model was carried out under a contract with California State University in San Diego, where Brazilian and North American education experts collaborated to design a new system. Censorship under the military regime further restricted discourse in schools and universities, suppressing public debates and preserving narratives that demonized Indigenous peoples as obstacles to national development.[34] This censorship added another layer to the silencing of the Doctrine of Discovery, contributing to the construction of a national narrative rooted in Eurocentrism and U.S.-backed neo-colonialism in South America.

The Role of Jesuits in Colonial Brazil: Exploitation and the Doctrine of Discovery

The involvement of the Jesuits in the exploitation and oppression of Indigenous peoples in Brazil presents a complex and multifaceted historical narrative. While a full exploration of their role is beyond the scope of this article, their influence, both historically and in the present, must be acknowledged. Even today, Jesuit institutions continue to play a significant role in the production of knowledge within Brazil, wielding considerable influence over the country's educational system - a privilege historically reserved for the elite classes.

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[30] Nina Menezes Cunha, *Religiosidade e Desempenho Escolar: O Caso de Jovens Brasileiros Da Região Metropolitana de Belo Horizonte*, Universidade Federal de Minas Gerais, 2012.

[31] Darllen Almeida Da Silva and Norma Iracema De Barros Ferreira, "Hegemonia Global Estadunidense e Os Acordos MEC/USAID (1965-1968)," *Revista Internacional de Educação Superior* 10 (January 2023): e024034, https://doi.org/10.20396/riesup.v10i00.8657974.

[32] M M Alves, *Beabá Dos MEC-USAID* (E. Gernasa, 1968), https://issuu.com/alexandremaciel/docs/mec-usaid; Talita Franciel Bordignon, "A Aliança Para o Progresso e a Educação Como Pretexto Para a Consolidação Do Capitalismo," *Anais Do XXVI Simpósio Nacional de História* (São Paulo), ANPUH, 2013, https://www.snh2013.anpuh.org/resources/anais/14/1300881299_ARQUIVO_AAliancaparaoProgressoeaeducacaocomopretextoparaaconsolidacaodocapitalismo.pdf.

[33] Paulo Freire, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (Penguin Education, 2005), 158, https://www.penguin.co.uk/books/22583/pedagogy-of-the-oppressed-by-freire-paulo/9780241301111.

[34] W. Michael Weis, "The Twilight of Pan-Americanism: The Alliance for Progress, Neo-Colonialism, and Non-Alignment in Brazil, 1961-1964," *The International History Review* 23, no. 2 (2001): 322–44.

It is crucial to understand that the Jesuits were part of a larger colonial apparatus, and their activities often aligned with the broader colonial agenda of the Portuguese Empire. More often than not, Jesuit policies and actions supported the interests of the colonial authorities, contributing to the oppression and displacement of Indigenous communities in favor of European settlers. While their role in the exploitation of Indigenous peoples was not always overtly malicious, it was far from altruistic. Jesuit missions frequently relied on Indigenous labor, particularly through enslavement, to sustain their economic ventures. These missions were not merely religious outposts but were deeply integrated into the colonial economy, establishing vast plantations and participating in agricultural and mining enterprises that exploited Indigenous labor.[35]

In the broader context of Portuguese colonization, the Catholic Church, including the Jesuits, played a pivotal role. For instance, Portuguese ships began transporting Indigenous captives back to Europe as early as 1511. Records from the time show that the ship *Bretoa* arrived in Portugal from Brazil carrying 35 Indigenous captives, alongside Brazilwood logs, jaguar skins, and parrots.[36] Such voyages, which intensified with the arrival of the Jesuits in Brazil in 1549, marked the beginning of the systematic exploitation of Indigenous peoples for economic gain. By this time, São Vicente, the captaincy of Martim Afonso de Sousa,[37] a prominent Portuguese nobleman and leader of the first major Portuguese expedition to establish settlements in Brazil, already had around 3,000 enslaved Indigenous workers laboring in its sugar mills. The Jesuits, following suit, enslaved Indigenous people to meet their own economic needs.[38]

The arrival of the Jesuits coincided with the peak of mercantilist expansionism, which was a key driver of the colonial predation on Indigenous lands and labor. From the issuance of *Dum Diversas* in 1452, which sanctioned the enslavement of non-Christians, to the Jesuits' arrival in Brazil, the Catholic Church was deeply entangled in the colonial project. The primary objective was to integrate Indigenous labor into the colonial mercantile economy, particularly through plantation agriculture.[39] In collaboration with the Portuguese government, the Catholic Church worked to dismantle Indigenous organizational structures, weakening any leadership that could resist colonization.[40]

By the mid-18th century, the exploitation of Indigenous lands had reached its zenith, with tons of gold and precious stones extracted and shipped back to Portugal. Historian Pandiá

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[35] Martin Carnoy, *Education as Cultural Imperialism*, with Internet Archive (Longman, 1977), http://archive.org/details/educationascultu00carn.

[36] Laurentino Gomes, *Escravidão – Vol. 1: Do Primeiro Leilão De Cativos Em Portugal até a Morte De Zumbi Dos Palmares* (Globo Livros, 2019).

[37] The **captaincy system** was a method used by the Portuguese crown in the 16th century to manage and develop its overseas colonies, including Brazil. The Brazilian territory was divided into large land grants known as **captaincies**, which were given to noblemen, or *donatários*, who were responsible for the administration, defense, and economic development of their respective regions. The *donatário* would govern the captaincy on behalf of the king, often by exploiting natural resources, establishing settlements, and organizing agricultural production. C. R. (Charles Ralph) Boxer, *The Golden Age of Brazil: Growing Pains of a Colonial Society, 1695-1750* (University of California Press, 1995), https://cir.nii.ac.jp/crid/1130282269261147392.

[38] Martim Afonso de Sousa was granted the captaincy of São Vicente, located on the southern coast of modern-day Brazil, near present-day São Paulo. This region, known as the Captaincy of São Vicente, became one of the first successful Portuguese colonies in Brazil. Sousa arrived in Brazil in 1531, leading a large fleet tasked with both defending the Portuguese territories from potential threats (such as French incursions) and laying the foundations for permanent colonization. He founded the town of São Vicente in 1532, which is considered the first formal Portuguese settlement in Brazil. J Gorender, O Escravismo Colonial (Ática, 1993).

[39] Carnoy, Education as Cultural Imperialism; Indigenous Values Initiative, "Dum Diversas: Doctrine of Discovery Project," 2018, https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/dum-diversas/.

[40] E Hoonaert, "Amazônia e a Cobiça Dos Europeus," in *História Da Igreja Na Amazônia*, ed. Coord E Hoonaert (Petrópolis, 1992).

Calogeras estimates that between the mid-18th and early 19th centuries, approximately 3 million carats, or 615 kilograms (1,355 pounds), of diamonds were mined from Indigenous lands.[41] By 1760, nearly half of the world's gold production came from Brazil, with enslaved Indigenous peoples performing much of the labor. In total, it is estimated that between 1,000 and 3,000 tons of gold were extracted from Indigenous territories and sent to Lisbon.

This process of territorial expansion, economic exploitation, and cultural suppression had devastating consequences for Brazil's Indigenous populations. By 1600, a century after the arrival of the Portuguese, the Indigenous population in the Americas had been reduced to just 10 million - a mere fraction of the pre-contact population. In Brazil, forced labor, combined with epidemics such as smallpox, ravaged Indigenous communities, killing thousands, including many children, who were especially vulnerable to disease outbreaks.

The justification for such exploitation was often couched in religious terms. The Portuguese used the maxim, *The Kingdom of God is identified with that of Portugal*, to legitimize their oppression of Indigenous peoples, equating their colonial ambitions with divine will.[42] This rhetoric was deeply influenced by the Doctrine of Discovery, which provided the moral and legal framework for European colonial expansion. Over time, the idea of a divinely ordained colonial mission would be echoed in the American doctrine of Manifest Destiny, which similarly justified the dispossession of Indigenous peoples in North America. Despite the temporal and geographic distance between these doctrines, they both served the same purpose: to impose the colonizer's culture on the colonized and legitimize their exploitation.

The Doctrine of Discovery, although originating in the 15th century, continues to resonate in various forms across the globe, perpetuating its racist and colonial principles. Its legacy is evident not only in the historical context of Brazil but in many other regions that experienced European colonization. Today, the remnants of these doctrines continue to shape global power dynamics, cultural interactions, and Indigenous rights movements.

Conclusion

The narrative of the irrelevance of the Doctrine, much like the myth of Brazil as a racial democracy, must be deconstructed to expose how colonial legacies continue to shape the country's reality. This project positions itself as a key intervention in how we understand contemporary forms of violence, specifically the historical roots of white supremacy and the control over knowledge production that have long been entrenched in Brazilian society.

Recognizing the Doctrine of Discovery as a critical element in Brazil's colonial history allows us to link it with modern struggles for Indigenous rights and social justice. The silence surrounding the Doctrine's role in shaping Brazil's colonial and postcolonial structures of power must be broken, much like the myth of racial harmony was challenged in previous decades. To deconstruct the "irrelevance" of the Doctrine is to open the way for meaningful dialogue about the historical processes that continue to perpetuate inequality. This intervention can help reframe how we think about sovereignty, decolonization, and the role of education in challenging entrenched systems of power. By situating the Doctrine of Discovery within the broader framework of historical injustice, we open new possibilities for addressing the

[41] João Pandiá Calogeras, *Formação Histórica Do Brasil* (Companhia Editora Nacional, 1957).
[42] Hoonaert, "Amazônia e a Cobiça Dos Europeus."

long-standing issues of racism, land dispossession, and the marginalization of Indigenous peoples. Moreover, acknowledging the Doctrine's legacy offers a pathway to reconciliation, healing, and the recognition of Indigenous sovereignty, both in Brazil and globally.

Ultimately, by engaging in these discussions, we take the first steps towards dismantling the systems of violence and exclusion that the Doctrine of Discovery set in motion. This project calls for continued research and action that seeks to challenge the dominant narratives of colonialism and imperialism and aims to foster a more inclusive and just society.

Timeline

1452
Dum Diversas – Pope Nicholas V issued the papal bull *Dum Diversas* on June 18, 1452. It authorized Alfonso V of Portugal to reduce Saracens (Muslims), pagans, and any other unbelievers to perpetual slavery.

1454
Publication of the Gutenberg Bible, the first book printed in Europe.

1454
Romanus Pontifex – Pope Nicholas V issued the papal bull *Romanus Pontifex* on January 8, 1454. It praised Catholic King Afonso V of Portugal and instructed him to capture and subdue all Saracens, Turks, and non-Christians, reducing them to perpetual slavery.

1492
On October 12, in a journey sponsored by Spanish Catholic Monarchs Queen Isabella I and King Ferdinand II, Italian explorer and navigator Columbus landed in the Americas, specifically in the Bahamas, known by the local inhabitants as Guanahani.

1493
Inter caetera – Pope Alexander VI issued the papal bull on May 4, 1493. It granted the Catholic Monarchs King Ferdinand II of Aragon and Queen Isabella I of Castile all lands to the west and south of a pole-to-pole line 100 leagues west and south of any of the islands of the Azores or Cabo Verde Islands.
1494
The Treaty of Tordesillas was signed on June 7, 1494. It modified *Inter caetera*, dividing newly discovered lands outside Europe between the Portuguese Empire and the Spanish Empire (Crown of Castile), along a meridian 500 miles west of Cabo Verde islands, off the west coast of Africa.

1498
Duarte Pacheco Pereira, a Portuguese explorer, arrived from voyages planned by Portuguese King D. Manuel for the expansion of the Portuguese Empire. Pacheco's reports describe a large mainland with many large islands nearby (later published in secretive manuscripts *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis*, which remained classified for four centuries).

1500
In April, Pedro Álvares Cabral, a Portuguese nobleman, military commander, navigator, and explorer, made landfall in what would later be known as Brazil. The new land fell within the Portuguese sphere according to the 1494 Treaty of Tordesillas.

1511
The ship *Bretoa* arrives in Portugal carrying 35 captive Brazilian Indigenous people, along with parrots, jaguar skins, and Brazilwood logs.

1515
Auction of 85 enslaved Brazilian Indigenous people in Valencia, Spain.
1530

Portuguese Martim Afonso de Sousa begins the colonization of Brazil.

1534
Brazil is divided into Donatary Captaincies. The Society of Jesus (Jesuits) is founded by Ignatius of Loyola.

1545
São Vicente, the captaincy of Martim Afonso de Sousa, has around 3,000 enslaved Indigenous people working on sugar mills.

1549
Arrival of the first Jesuits in Brazil.

1573
A copy of the secret manuscript *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis* by Duarte Pacheco Pereira was secretly sent to Philip II of Spain by the Italian spy Giovanni Gesio, under the service of the Spanish ambassador in Lisbon. A copy is now housed at the library of El Escorial Monastery in Spain.[43]

1600
The Indigenous population of the Americas is estimated at 10 million - only one-fifth of the number that existed at the time of European arrival. In Brazil, smallpox epidemics decimated tens of thousands of Indigenous people.

1627
Vicente do Salvador, a Franciscan friar, published the first history of Brazil. He studied at the prestigious Jesuit College of Salvador, Bahia, Brazil, and later at the University of Coimbra, where he majored. He is considered the father of Brazilian history, though his works do not reference the relationship between the Catholic Church and the Portuguese Crown.

1632
Portuguese explorer Raposo Tavares enslaved between 40,000 and 60,000 Indigenous people in Brazil.

1648
Raposo Tavares traveled over 10,000 kilometers (6,200 miles) through Brazilian lands, following rivers in search of gold, precious minerals, and Indigenous people to enslave. He was accompanied by 200 white mercenaries and over a thousand enslaved Indigenous people.

1687
São Paulo, the largest city in Brazil, had 1,500 inhabitants and 10,000 enslaved Indigenous people.

1697
The first shipment of gold bars extracted from Indigenous lands in Brazil arrived in Lisbon, Portugal.

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[43] Bailey W. (Bailey Wallys) Diffie, *Foundations of the Portuguese Empire, 1415-1580*, with Internet Archive (University of Minnesota Press, 1977), http://archive.org/details/foundationsofpor0000diff.

1729
Tons of gold and precious stones were extracted from Indigenous lands in Brazil and sent to Portugal. Historian Pandiá Calogeras (1870–1934) estimated that 3 million carats, or 615 kilograms (about 1,355.84 pounds), of diamonds were mined in Brazil between the mid-18th century and the early 19th century.[44]

1750
The Treaty of Madrid was signed between Portugal and Spain, revoking the Treaty of Tordesillas and defining new boundaries for their colonies.

1760
It is estimated that between 1,000 and 3,000 tons of gold were removed from Brazilian Indigenous lands and taken to Lisbon, Portugal, representing approximately half of the world's gold.

1773
The first publication of the letter by Pero Vaz de Caminha was censored by the Portuguese Crown since 1500. The 1860 oil painting *The First Mass in Brazil* by Victor Meirelles was based on the letter's descriptions of the event, providing a visual account of the possession ritual.

1784
Haiti gained independence from France and abolished slavery.

1822
On September 7, Portuguese regent Dom Pedro proclaimed the independence of Brazil. On December 1, Pedro I was crowned the first Emperor of Brazil. Brazil was the largest slave territory in the Americas, with enslaved people making up more than a third of the population, estimated at 4.7 million. Rio de Janeiro, the capital of the new Empire, was the largest city in the Americas, with about 10% of the population enslaved.

1833
Britain abolished slavery.

1848
Denmark and France abolished slavery.

1872
The painting *American Progress* by John Gast symbolized the modernization of the New West and reflected the Manifest Destiny belief in the 19th-century U.S., which held that American settlers were destined to expand across North America.

1888
Brazil abolished slavery.

1890
Brazilian Minister of Finance Rui Barbosa ordered the destruction of all slavery-related archives by burning any records associated with it.

1914

[44] Calogeras, *Formação Histórica Do Brasil.*

Theodore Roosevelt, former President of the United States, participated in the Roosevelt-Rondon Expedition into the Amazon, where many Indigenous peoples lived.

1963
Thirty-five hundred (3,500) Indigenous members of the Cinta Larga group were murdered under the orders of a rubber company operating in the Amazon.

1964
On March 31, the Brazilian Armed Forces, with U.S. government support, overthrew democratically elected President João Goulart, initiating a 21-year military dictatorship. The dictatorship, aided by
U.S. and U.K. advisors, was marked by arbitrary arrests, imprisonment without trial, kidnapping, torture, disappearances, rape, and assassinations.

1964
After being imprisoned as a traitor for 70 days, Brazilian educator Paulo Freire went into exile.

1965
MEC/USAID agreements, imposed by the U.S. government, restructured Brazil's educational system, shifting the focus from the humanities to creating a labor force that would strengthen capitalism in line with U.S. interests in the region.

1968
In exile, Paulo Freire published his most famous work, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*. The book was banned in Brazil and went unpublished there until 1974.

1985
End of military dictatorship without direct elections.

2004
Massacre of Cinta Larga Indigenous people in the Amazon Forest.

2023
The Yanomami Indigenous people in the Amazon remain in a humanitarian crisis. Many are dying due to illegal mining and logging activities by transnational companies. Local and international authorities have described the situation as genocide [45]

[45] Survival International, "'Lost' Report Exposes Brazilian Indian Genocide," 2013, https://www.survivalinternational.org/news/9191.